



WHERE DO I COME FROM?

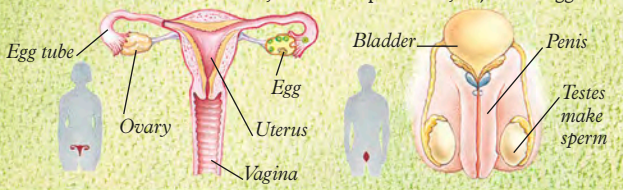


You began your life as an egg, which was only about the size of this period.

This tiny fertilized egg grew for about nine months inside your mother before you were born. While a baby is growing, it relies on the mother for everything, and although a baby cannot do very much when it is first born, already it is a complete and very special person.

The beginning

Everyone is made up of billions of living units, called cells. A baby starts when an egg cell from a woman and a sperm cell from a man join together to make one new cell. For the egg and sperm to meet, the man and woman must have sexual intercourse. This is sometimes called making love because the man and woman treat each other lovingly. The man's penis gets firm and he puts it into the woman's vagina. The penis releases a mixture called semen, which has sperm in it, to join the egg.



Sperm are like tiny tadpoles with long tails. They swim to the tube to find the egg. One sperm may then fertilize the egg.

The fertilized egg grows and divides into two.

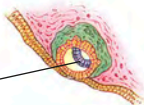


It divides into four, eight, sixteen, and so on...



While it is dividing, it is traveling to the womb, or uterus.

After nine days the egg attaches itself to the wall of the uterus.



After about eight weeks, the group of cells starts to look more like a baby.



The fingers, toes, and face are formed.

